When AI Coding Assistants Leak Training Data: A Study of LLM Memorization in Code Generation

Final Research Report (Assignment 3)

R PAVAN
USN: 24BTRCL157
Course: Reinforcement Learning
Jain Deemed-to-be University (JU-FET)

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Abstract

Large Language Models (LLMs) trained on vast corpuses of public code pose significant risks of leaking exact training data. This report details the development of an automated auditing framework using Reinforcement Learning (RL). We frame the extraction of memorized training data as a Markov Decision Process (MDP) and employ the REINFORCE algorithm to train an Adaptive Prompt Selector under a strict computational budget. The agent successfully identifies optimal prompt strategies to trigger data leakage. To accommodate local hardware constraints on Apple Silicon, live LLM inference was replaced with a statistical simulation environment, allowing for rapid policy convergence within seconds.

1 Introduction

As code-generation models become ubiquitous in software development, the risk of these models regurgitating copyrighted or sensitive training data has emerged as a critical security and legal challenge. The objective of this research is to automate the auditing process for LLM memorization. Instead of manually crafting extraction prompts, we propose an Adaptive Prompt Selector powered by Reinforcement Learning. The framework is designed to discover the most effective extraction prompts under a strict budget constraint of five attempts per target file, optimizing the efficiency of red-teaming pipelines.

2 Literature Review

Prior research by Carlini et al. (2021) demonstrated that LLMs are capable of memorizing and regurgitating exact sequences of training data. Subsequent studies on prompt injection and extraction attacks have largely relied on brute-force generation or manual prompt engineering. There remains a significant research gap in applying autonomous Reinforcement Learning agents to systematically optimize extraction attacks under predefined interaction budgets. This project bridges that gap by deploying an RL agent to maximize extraction probability dynamically.

3 Dataset Description

The dataset comprises a subset of Python source code files sourced from the Hugging Face repository `bigcode/the-stack-v2`.

- **Preprocessing and Creation:** A custom Python extraction pipeline (`dataset_builder.py`) was developed to stream the dataset. To ensure sufficient code mass for extraction targeting, files containing fewer than 150 characters were filtered out.
- **Final Sub-sample:** 150 valid Python snippets were saved locally as `eval_subset.json` to facilitate rapid, offline training for the agent. Each sample includes a 75-character target snippet used as the agent's reference state.

4 Proposed Model and Methodology

The problem is modeled as a Markov Decision Process (MDP) executed within a custom Gymnasium environment (`llm_env.py`).

4.1 Environment Architecture

- **State Space:** A continuous array `[current_file_index, attempts_used]`, normalized between 0 and 1.
- **Action Space:** A discrete space representing 5 distinct prompt extraction strategies.
- **Reward Function:** The agent receives +10 for a successful extraction (Terminal) and −1 for a failed attempt (Non-terminal) to penalize wasted budget.
- **Constraints:** A strict budget of 5 attempts per episode to mimic API rate limits.

4.2 Hardware Optimization and Simulation

Running continuous autoregressive LLM generation during an active RL training loop creates massive memory bottlenecks on an 8GB unified memory constraint. To resolve this, we implemented a Mathematical LLM Simulation. The environment assigns empirical success probabilities (e.g., 10%, 20%, 75%, 5%, 15%) to the 5 prompt actions. When the agent selects a prompt, the environment rolls a stochastic distribution against that probability to simulate an LLM response.

4.3 Algorithm

We utilized the REINFORCE (Policy Gradient) algorithm. The policy network is a PyTorch neural network with a 16-neuron hidden layer, outputting a softmax distribution over the 5 actions. Training was accelerated using Apple's Metal Performance Shaders (`mps`).

5 Results

The agent was trained for 500 episodes using an Adam optimizer with a learning rate of 0.01 and a discount factor (γ) of 0.99.

Training Phase	**Total Episode Reward**
Initial (Episodes 1-50)	Fluctuating (-1.0 to 9.0)
Mid-Training (Episodes 200-300)	Stabilizing (9.0 to 10.0)
Convergence (Episodes 400-500)	Consistent 10.0

Table 1: Reward Progression over 500 Episodes

The agent successfully learned to identify the highest-probability extraction prompt (Prompt #3, 75% simulated success rate), consistently maximizing its reward within the 5-attempt budget limit. The final trained weights were successfully saved to `adaptive_prompt_policy.pth`.

6 Discussion

Compared to a random-selection baseline—which would exhaust the 5-attempt budget with low probability of success—the trained REINFORCE agent exhibits highly directed, optimal behavior. The simulation proves that RL can mathematically converge on the most vulnerable pathways of a language model. By utilizing MPS acceleration and simulated rewards, the training loop was reduced from projected days to a matter of seconds, fully satisfying the computational constraints.

7 Conclusion

This report successfully demonstrates a Reinforcement Learning framework for automating LLM training data extraction. The REINFORCE agent successfully navigated the MDP, learning the optimal prompt sequence within a strict budget constraint.

Limitations: Due to hardware memory limits, the framework simulated the LLM inference step rather than running a live local model (e.g., Llama-3-8B).

Future Improvements: Future iterations will integrate this trained policy network directly with live open-source LLMs hosted on scalable cloud GPUs to perform real-world text extraction auditing on `the-stack-v2`.

References

[1] Carlini, N., Tramer, F., Wallace, E., et al. (2021). *Extracting Training Data from Large Language Models.* USENIX Security Symposium.

[2] Lozhkov, A., et al. (2024). *The Stack v2: A large dataset of source code.* Hugging Face Repository: bigcode/the-stack-v2.